



Solution Architect, Final Challenge (Acme)

 Candidate handout. We're excited to keep moving forward here!

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Acme: Embedded Engagement & Renewal Defense

Objective

You're a Solution Architect embedded on the **Acme, Inc.** account. The Acme AI Deployment Manager (ADM) has pulled you in for three intertwined reasons:

1. A specific Acme team has surfaced a real use case that needs hands-on technical leadership.
2. The account heads into a **significant renewal in ~90 days with no executive champion**, and the ADM needs the engagement you run with the customer to ladder up to a defensible renewal narrative.
3. The ADM wants this engagement to seed a more **automated software factory** at Acme, plan, design, build, review, test, and deploy increasingly running through Cursor, so people across roles (PM, QA, DevOps), not only engineers, can become builders. Treat the onboarding use case as the wedge toward that.

Your task: lead a **role-play driven working session** showing how you'd partner with the ADM, take technical leadership, prototype alongside the customer, teach them to own it, and capture the evidence the ADM needs to protect the renewal. **It runs about 60 minutes: ~45 minutes leading the working session, plus ~15 for wrap-up and feedback.**

Acme use case

As a reminder, the customer team wants to cut time-to-productivity for new engineers onboarding to their internal library from weeks to days: *"Can Cursor 3x how fast new engineers become productive contributors to it, and help them ship cleanly through design, review, test, and deploy?"*

The team also cares how this lands with the partners around engineering (PM, QA, DevOps): a strong solution improves the whole workflow, not just one engineer's onboarding.

The session (you lead, role-play)

This is a **live role-play, not a discussion**. You lead a working session with your **internal Cursor account team**, played by your **two interviewers**, who flex across roles as the session turns: an **Account Executive** (and **Field Engineer** when technical), your **ADM**, and a **Regional Director (RD, the sales regional director)**, your future co-workers, **not the customer**. They'll voice the customer's likely reactions and push back, but no one is playing the customer. Address them by name, and run the session however you like, slides, a live demo, a whiteboard, whatever best drives the plan; there's no prescribed format.

How the session runs (prepare to lead each part):

1. **Align with your ADM** on the engagement.
2. **Frame and solve the customer's problem** with the assets at your disposal.
3. **Give a renewal-defense readout** for account leadership.
4. **Close with three things you'd need from Cursor leadership** to be successful.

Throughout, think out loud, we care as much about how you reason and problem-solve as the final answer.

Pull your context from the **Scenario Pack** (appendix below): kickoff email, account snapshot, telemetry, champion artifacts, the cross-functional players, and an exec-skepticism signal.

Build on what you already made

This is the key difference from a typical take-home. You will *extend the artifact you built in your technical screen*. You are not starting over. Treat the open-source library you used there as the stand-in for Acme's internal SDK, and evolve your artifact to fit this account.

This session is **lighter on technical internals** than your screen; we already saw your depth there. Here we're focused on how you **think, partner, and create customer value**. A light, working demo is welcome, but polished mechanics are not the point. You won't need to repeat your technical-screen demo; showing the asset you built is fine where it helps set context or serves the exercise.

This challenge is Cursor-specific. Your prototype and demo must be in **Cursor**, and we want to see you apply Cursor's specific capabilities (rules, commands, MCP, agents, custom modes, cloud agents) to Acme's situation. If you used a different tool for your technical screen, bring the relevant work into Cursor for this stage. We're looking for how you position and apply *Cursor* in an enterprise context, not AI coding in the abstract.

Before the session (async)

Engagement email / plan to your ADM (role-play), **due the day before** the session: a short written piece (email or one-pager) on how you'll attack the engagement, what you need from the ADM, and how you'll prove value for the renewal. Keep it tight and specific. Email it to the hiring manager, and use the subject line `<YOUR NAME> - Challenge - Solution Plan` so it doesn't get lost.

What to bring

1. **Your extended prototype in Cursor:** your Stage 3 artifact, evolved to solve the onboarding problem. Runnable, not slideware.
2. **A co-build & enablement plan:** what the next 2–3 working sessions with the Acme team look like, how you shift ownership from you to their engineers so it doesn't become a permanent crutch, and how the workflow interlocks with PM (planning), QA/testing, and DevOps (CI/CD), not just individual engineers.
3. **A renewal-defense pack:** the empirical evidence you'll capture hands-on during the engagement, plus champion-sourced quotes and before/after artifacts. This is raw evidence and capture mechanisms for the ADM, not an

exec deck. Identify a **primary champion candidate** and explain how you'd choreograph the engagement around them. **Anchor the defense on 3 of these 5 metrics** and be ready to defend why those three:

- Time-to-first-meaningful-PR for new joiners (ramp velocity)
- PR-rejection / rework rate during ramp (quality)
- Weekly active / provisioned seats (adoption + expansion)
- Senior-engineer interrupt volume during ramp (leverage)
- Design → deploy cycle time for a new joiner's change (SDLC reach)

4. **A leadership ask:** be ready to name **three specific things you'd need from Cursor leadership** to succeed as the SA on this account. Concrete (product, GTM, enablement, exec support), not generic.

What we're looking for

- **Problem framing & judgment**
- **Visible thinking** (we weight the process as much as the output)
- **Use-case-to-solution translation**
- **ADM partnership & champion development**
- **Consultative reach across the SDLC and partner teams**
- **Software-factory vision**
- **Value capture & renewal defense**
- **Teach-to-fish instinct**
- **Executive presence & communication**

Resources

- Cursor (tell your recruiter if you need extra usage credits)
- Cursor Docs and any public documentation
- Public docs for the open-source library you're using as the SDK stand-in
- The Scenario Pack (appendix below)

Questions? Reach out to the team any time.

Appendix: Scenario Pack

Fictional company and metrics; no real Cursor or customer data. Deliberately under-specified, make explicit assumptions, pick a path, and defend it.

1. ADM kickoff email (role-play)

From: Your ADM (AI Deployment Manager, Acme account)

To: You (Solution Architect)

Cc: [Hiring Manager]

Subject: Acme, let's get ahead of the renewal

Hey, thanks for jumping in. Quick context before we meet.

Acme has had Cursor in pockets for ~9 months, but it's uneven and the renewal is ~90 days out with no executive champion. **One of their engineering teams** has a real, concrete pain: new engineers take ~6 weeks to make a meaningful contribution to their internal library, and leadership wants that cut dramatically. That's our wedge.

I need you to take technical leadership of an engagement with that team, prototype something with them, teach them to own it, and capture evidence I can take into the renewal. I've got eleven other accounts, so I need you to run point and tell me exactly what you need from me.

Come to our working session with: how you'd attack this, a working artifact, a champion plan, and what value you'll capture.

2. Account snapshot

Company	Acme, Inc. (fictional, enterprise software)

Provisioned Cursor seats	~1,200 across ~18 engineering teams
Active usage	~6 teams meaningfully active; long tail dormant
Technical pain	new engineers take ~6 weeks to make a meaningful contribution to the team's internal library; ramp is the bottleneck
Renewal	~90 days out; multi-year renewal under review
Tool landscape	Cursor, Codex, and Claude Code all in use, no single standard
Leadership concern	fragmented workflows, duplicated spend, unclear ROI
Champion status	none at the exec level; strong grassroots pockets

3. Usage telemetry (fictional)

Metric	Value
Weekly active / provisioned seats	38%
The customer team	12 engineers, high Cursor usage
New-engineer time-to-first-meaningful-PR (the team)	~6 weeks
Teams that piloted then stalled	2
Most-used Cursor features (the team)	Tab, agent, ad-hoc chat; few custom rules/commands

4. "Found" artifacts, potential champions

- **Maya Chen, Staff Engineer on the team.** Internal post: *"I wrote a set of Cursor rules for our library's conventions, cut my own ramp on the new module in half."* Writes docs, evangelizes to peers. Strong technical believer; limited exec reach.
- **David Park, Engineering Manager on the team.** In a planning doc: *"Onboarding is our biggest drag, 6 weeks to productive is too slow."* Owns the team's goals; org leverage; lukewarm on tools personally.
- **Priya Nair, Director of Engineering.** Asked in a staff meeting: *"What's actually moving our new-hire ramp curve?"* Not a current Cursor user; controls the renewal conversation.

5. Executive-skepticism signal

Forwarded note: *"Finance is comparing Cursor line-by-line to Codex's and Claude Code's enterprise pricing. Before the renewal, leadership wants to see what Cursor delivers that the others don't, in numbers."*

6. Additional players (the cross-functional interlock)

The engagement does not live with engineers alone. Expect these stakeholders in play around the team, each with a stake you'll need to win over:

- **Nina Alvarez, QA / Test Lead.** Owns test strategy and coverage gates; wary that faster onboarding could mean more under-tested PRs.
- **Marcus Webb, DevOps / Platform owner.** Owns CI/CD and the guardrails new code must clear; cares what actually reaches the pipeline.
- **Ravi Shah, Product Manager on the team.** Owns the roadmap; wants the onboarding gain tied to delivery velocity and outcomes.